

Grown-up's Playbook: Pook's Tangled Paths

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Pook's Tangled Paths: Rules for the Grown-Up

New to this? Read the Guide for the Grown-Up first. It explains the whole idea in two pages and you will never need it again.

You are the Game Master, which here means a few small jobs at once: storyteller, gentle referee, the children's biggest fan, and a fellow adventurer who plays along. This is a cooperative game for two or more who play together, a grown-up and one or more children, all on the same side. Nobody competes, and nobody loses. This is a gentle tale: the only "foe" is a lonely faerie who simply wants a friend, and no one is ever truly hurt.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Roundhouse.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Cleverness** (a clever plan), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Kindness** (caring for others). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a ball of string for the red wool, a small cake or token for the honey oatcake, and a leaf or twig for the sprig of oak. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

Difficulty bands, not dice

Challenges never call for a particular die. Each one has a band: **Easy**, **Normal**, or **Hard**.

When the players try something, look up the band on the kit's dice-band table, which tells you the number to meet or beat with whatever dice your family owns. Every challenge can be played with a single ordinary die.

The golden rule: here nobody loses

A failed roll is never a defeat. It is a detour to a different route. When a roll does not meet the band, the players always have a way through:

- **Spend an energy star** to gather themselves and try the idea again, or
- **Join two qualities** once per stop to pass with no roll at all (Cleverness and Kindness together, say, or Courage and Cleverness).

Energy stars come back when the players move on to the next stop, and when they help each other. Nobody can ever run dry for long, and nobody is ever stuck.

Helping each other: the Helping Hand

At any moment one player may help another instead of acting alone. When they do, make the help roll: on a success the challenge is passed for the pair, even if the first roll missed.

Helping is generous, so reward it; it also tops up an energy star. In this grove, no hero stands alone.

The Twist of Fate

At each stop, once, the players may roll for a twist and you read out the matching line. Use whichever die the dice-band table gives you for this; with a single ordinary die, read the line that matches the number rolled.

Roll

Twist of Fate

1	Pook the Puca pops up and gives you one free hint.
2	You find your courage again, and take back one energy star.
3	A soft breeze through the oaks, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	The Salmon of Wisdom blows a lucky bubble. All is well.
5	A sprig of oak for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A burst of birdsong, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

Pook the Puca is the "foe", but he is no villain. He is a playful faerie who made a game of the paths and then felt sorry for the trouble it caused. The tale is won not by beating him but by befriending him: sharing the honey oatcake, sitting beside him, telling him there is a place for him at the fair. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. Befriended, Pook gladly untangles every path himself. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

Pook's Tangled Paths: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward cleverness and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: The Tangled Grove (Easy)

The challenge. The winding paths of the Whispering Oak Grove loop and double back, and the players keep arriving at the same old oak. They must find a way through without getting hopelessly lost.

Intended solution. This is a Cleverness and Spatial moment. The clever, kind move is to use the **ball of red wool**: tie one end at the entrance and unspool it as you go, so you can always retrace your steps and never walk the same wrong loop twice. Marking each turning, or following the thread back to try a new path, works just as well.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, let the red wool tug gently towards the true path, or have a friendly robin hop ahead from branch to branch. Getting through with a little help still counts as a full success and tops up an energy star.

Stop 2: Pook's Three Doors (Normal)

The challenge. Pook has grown three mossy archway doors of oak branches. Only one leads onward; the other two loop the players back. They must read his playful clues and choose the true door.

The clues. Read them aloud: *"The left door loves the morning sun, but it sends you back where you begun. The middle door is mossy and old, and it keeps a fib for every tale it told. The right door is quiet and small and true, and that is the door that will see you through."* The **right-hand door** is the way on: the left clue says plainly that it sends you back, the middle clue admits it tells fibs, and the right clue is the only one that calls itself true.

Intended solution. This is a Logic and Observation moment. Let the children talk the clues through together and listen for the door that says it is true while the others give themselves away. A thoughtful guess is welcome too.

Fallback. If they are stuck, read the clues again slowly, one door at a time, or let Pook lean in and whisper, "Listen to which door tells the truth." A door chosen bravely still creaks open onto the right path.

Stop 3: Winning Pook Over (Normal, then no roll)

The challenge. The players find Pook the Puca hunched on a toadstool, no longer laughing. He looks small and sorry. The children may wonder how to make things right.

Intended solution. This is a Kindness and Courage moment. Pook is simply a little ashamed and unsure how to say sorry. Any genuine kindness works: sharing the **honey oatcake**, sitting down beside him, telling him there is room for him at the May fair, saying that everyone makes a muddle sometimes. When the children are kind, Pook brightens and promises to set every path right himself.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or want to scold him, have Pook sniffle and ask, very quietly, "Are you cross with me too?" A single kind word melts him. The moment the players offer any friendly gesture at all, he hops up and undoes the whole tangle.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser. When Pook claps his paws, the ribbons of mist unwind, the paths of the grove run straight and true, and Pook skips along to lead the heroes out himself.

The May fair goes ahead in a swirl of music and dancing, and **Danu the Kind** smiles down from above the green isles. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being clever, brave, and kind.

Wits and Wonder

Grown-up's Playbook

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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Version 1.7, updated 2026-06-05, en-GB



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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.